

TURTLES

Most turtles spend nearly all their lives in water. For a few species, this is the sea, but there are also freshwater turtles, some of which are called terrapins. With streamlined shells and webbed feet or flippers, turtles are well made for swimming and diving.



TORTOISES

These slow-moving land-dwellers have strong shells, often with a high dome that is difficult for predators to bite. They have short, bent legs and strong, stumpy feet.

GALAPAGOS TORTOISES, THE LARGEST IN THE WORLD, CAN GROW UP TO 1.2 M (4 FT) LONG AND WEIGH UP TO 270 KG (595 LB)



Turtles and tortoises

There were turtles and tortoises on Earth even before the dinosaurs. They all belong to the same scientific group. The main difference between them is that turtles live in water and tortoises on land. All have shells and lay eggs.

INSIDE THE SHELL

Turtles and tortoises have an unusual skeleton. Their ribs, spine, and some other bones form part of the shell. In nearly all species, the shell has a bony inner layer covered by thin plates of keratin, the same material as human fingernails.

